MP, where the party had been in power for 18 of the last 20 years, resulting in high anti-incumbency for its chief minister, Shivraj Singh Chouhan. As many as seven MPs, including three Union ministers and one national general secretary, were awarded tickets in order to offer voters a wider choice.

The second strategy was to counter Congress freebies with targeted ones of their own, never mind that Modi in the past had dismissed Opposition parties for indulging in '*revdi*' politics. Days before the states went to the polls, the prime minister extended the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY), which will provide free foodgrains to over 800 million of the country's poorest citizens for the next five years. This was accompanied by the promise to enhance the bonus on the MSP (minimum support price)-linked purchase of paddy by Rs 500 (in Chhattisgarh), income support for farm labour, and a Rs 200 reduction in the prices of LPG cylinders.

Boosting the BJP's vote-catching abilities was a third strategy that focused on wooing socio-economic groups, especially women and youth. The 'Ladli Behna Yojana' and other women-centric schemes in MP resulted in the BJP gaining a 13 percentage point lead over the Congress in terms of the women's vote share, constituting a significant factor in the party's massive victory in the state. Special schemes for women in these states apart, the passage of the Women's Reservations Bill by the Centre in September, reserving a third of the seats in Parliament, cemented their support further. The BJP also trained its attention on Scheduled Castes and Tribes, cohorts that had deserted them in previous elections.

The fourth strategy was the ruthless selection of candidates, with winnability, not loyalty, the chief criterion for receiving a ticket. In Chhattisgarh, for instance, 55 of the total of 90 BJP candidates were fresh faces. In MP, almost a third of the BJP MLAs were denied tickets because of their poor performance.

DEFLATING THE CONGRESS

The trump card in the BJP's winning pack of cards, however, was the fifth strategy. It saw Modi take the bold but risky decision to pit himself directly against the Congress satraps in the northern states and use his huge popularity and credibility to swing a decisive chunk of votes his party's way. In all, Modi addressed 34 rallies in the three states. In MP and Rajasthan, he addressed 15 rallies each and smartly appropriated the Congress freebie plank by rechristening them "Modi's guarantees". His name was even inserted in the party's slogans for the two states—'MP ke mann mein Modi hai' and 'Modi sathe apno Rajasthan'. The India Today-Axis My India exit poll results show that 17 per cent of the voters in Rajasthan voted for the BJP because of Modi.

The outcome of all these efforts was spectacular wins for the BJP and a ringing endorsement of PM Modi's leadership and programmes. In MP, the BJP managed to buck 18 years of anti-incumbency, and retain the state with a two-thirds majority. The party won 163 of the state's 230 seats and netted a vote share of 48.55 per cent, a boost of seven percentage points from its 2018 performance. In Rajasthan, it managed to wrest power from the Ashok Gehlot-led Congress, which had been trumpeting a welfarist narrative of the kind that had helped the BJP win in other states. The party won 115 of Rajasthan's 199 seats (election to the Karanpur seat will be held on January 5) and, contrary to its own expectations, won Chhattisgarh too, claiming 54 of its 90 seats. The three states together have 65 seats in the Lok Sabha, of which the BJP won 62 in the 2019 general election despite losing the assembly polls in all three states in 2018. It's a feat the party expects to repeat in 2024. If there is a dampener to the BJP's euphoria, it is the loss in Telangana, where, despite doubling its vote share to 14 per cent, it failed to stop the Congress from wresting power from the Bharat Rashtra Samithi.

However, the win is small consolation even for the Congress, whose rout in the three northern states has upset its game plan of positioning itself as the prime challenger to the BJP at the Centre. "What these results


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